CRIME

Back for Seconds

Few web shows are able to deliver a hit second season. *Delhi Crime* hopes to buck that trend



If it's the sequel that decides the fate of a popular film franchise, it is the second season which proves crucial for web shows. With its new season premiering on Netflix on August 26, *Delhi Crime* (2019—), the only Indian title to have ever won an International Emmy award, faces a litmus test that is, in some ways, unprecedented. While we can expect a similar grit we saw in the first season, it is important to note that writer-director Richie Mehta has relinquished some of his responsibilities to stay on only as an executive producer. With writing duties having been divided, Tanuj Chopra has come on board as director and showrunner. Even though Shefali Shah, the show's lead, thinks a comparison is "really unfair", it is inevitable this instalment will be weighed against the finesse of the first.

Shah, for her part, is confident that despite a new crew, audiences won't feel they are watching a new show. "Everyone knew the grain of *DC* (*Delhi Crime*)," she says. "There is nothing plastic about it. There is no lip gloss; it's just cracked lips and it's just beautiful. We've gone in with the same madness, passion and hard work." It helps that key cast members—Rasika Dugal, Rajesh Tailang, Gopal Dutt, Anurag Arora, Sidharth Bhardwaj—are reprising their roles. "In the first reading, it all fell into place," recalls Shah. Inspired by the Nirbhaya case, the first season dramatised how the Delhi Police captured a group of men who had been accused of gangrape. This time around, it's a series of grisly murders that have 'Madam Sir' a.k.a. DCP Vartika Chaturvedi (Shah) and her khaki squad facing the heat from the public, the media and politicians. Seeing that the victims are vulnerable senior citizens, fear and anger is only stoked more.

While the first season was more investigative drama, Shah and Dugal feel that it's the characters who take precedence in the second. With a year having passed, the characters have evolved when we meet them in the second season. Dugal's Neeti Singh, for instance, has been promoted; she is married, struggling hard to find a work-home balance. "We have gone deeper into the psyche," says Shah. "In season one, there was no wavering of the moral compass for anyone. In *DC2*, Vartika is human. She falters and she doesn't shy away from correcting [course], even at the cost of herself."

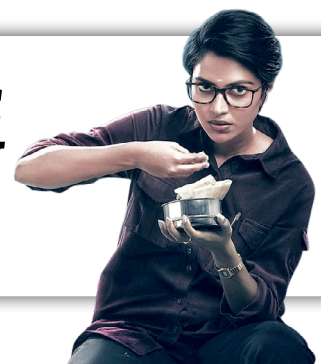
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These moral dilemmas become conspicuous as killings happen in affluent parts of the capital and suspicion falls upon those living on the city's fringes. "When you talk about a class divide, it's very prevalent and stark in Delhi—it's out there for you to see," says Dugal. Shah goes on to add, "It's how a big section of society marginalises another." Facing stiff competition from rivals, Netflix has been struggling to safeguard its global foothold. *Delhi Crime* comes at a pivotal time for it. Expectations are high from one of the few Indian originals that both worked locally and crossed over internationally. Another Emmy may be setting the bar too high, but Vartika and her team may well be the heroes Netflix now needs. ■

- Suhani Singh

OTHER STATES OF PLAY

New regional films and web shows to stream



TAMIL

Cadaver (Disney+ Hotstar)

In this film that Amala Paul has both starred in and produced, the actress plays Bhadra, a forensic surgeon who has all the wit and agency needed to find the culprit behind several high-profile murders.

